

THE NEW INTEREST

Away from the hype of Carla Bruni, Nicolas Sarkozy's visit will establish France as an all-weather partner of India

It is undoubtedly European winter in India's diplomatic circuit. Close on the heels of the British Prime Minister Gordon Brown, comes French President Nicolas Sarkozy, who is the chief guest at the Republic Day celebrations. Sarkozy's visit almost got Carla Bruni jacked but now it seems his charming companion Carla Bruni may not accompany him during his official trip to India.

In Delhi, besides attending the Republic Day ceremonies, Sarkozy will hold strategic talks with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh on issues such as nuclear, space and defence cooperation. Sarkozy's visit forms part of India's continued engagement with European giants, France and Britain, influential members of the global power pack.

France is eagerly awaiting the fate of the Indo-US nuclear deal which is a key to opening the doors to nuclear cooperation. It will enable France to revive its nuclear pact with India inked during President Jacques Chirac's visit last year. Then once the deal is finalised, armed with the Nuclear Suppliers Group's exception clause, France will be able to supply nuclear reactors to India.

Another issue which is expected to crop up during his visit is the multi-billion dollar Euro-copter deal to supply 197 light helicopters to the Army which was scrapped following some technical glitches. This had miffed France but now they have reasons to cheer as the Defence Ministry has called for fresh bids. The Defence Acquisition

MISSING BEAUTY:
Bruni may not accompany Sarkozy



FRENCH NAMASTE

NUCLEAR DEAL: France is eagerly awaiting the fate of the Indo-US nuclear deal as this will pave way for a nuclear deal with it as well.

DEFENCE: The Defence Acquisition Council has cleared the IAF's proposal for the upgradation of 50 Mirage 2000 fighter jets and an agreement may be announced.

Council had recently cleared the Indian Air Force's (IAF) proposal for the upgradation of 50 Mirage 2000 fighter jets. The upgrade, worth over \$2 billion (Rs 7,870 crore) will give a quantum leap in capabilities to the IAF's fleet of multi-role jets acquired from France in the mid-'80s. The Ministry of Defence is set to begin price negotiations with French firms, Thales and Dassault, for the upgradation which will reportedly cost \$40 million (Rs 160 crore) per jet. France is also

the key contender to supply a second line of six conventional submarines for the Indian Navy worth Rs 13,000 crore.

A key member of the United Nations Security Council, France is expected to renew its call for the expansion of the Security Council with India as a permanent member during Sarkozy's official trip. It also favours the expansion of the G-8 which may also be reflected in the joint statement that the two countries are negotiating. Not just this, Sarkozy is also expected to offer a green growth strategy for India and urge it to cut its emissions.

The right winger French President has built his bridges with Washington, but he is now looking to boost Paris's power quotient. He is upbeat over the recent deal with the UAE of a French military base there, which will ensure France's strategic presence in the Middle East, and in collaboration with India it can extend its outreach, which may be a strategic deliverable for this trip.

To woo Indian students, the French President may announce that foreign students will be allowed to work part-time while studying. Apart from this, agreements on human exchanges and cooperation in science and environment are also expected.

With France, India has many shared interests which will figure prominently during Sarkozy-Manmohan talks. Sources say there is convergence of views on many international issues like Pakistan, Iran and the Middle East. On Iran, where it has key oil stakes, France favours a carrot and stick approach to persuade Tehran to give up its nuclear programme. Although there are few differences between the countries, India may raise some concerns and on its part, Singh is expected to talk about lifting the ban on wearing of turbans in schools in France and discuss visa-related problems. Sarkozy may miss on a Taj date with Bruni, but his passage to India will strengthen the global partnership and provide some momentum to the bilateral ties.

by Saurabh Shukla

